

VERBS LIKE GUSTAR II

— Essential Guide

Beyond Gusta and Gustan

B1–B2

1 Gustar has more than two forms

At beginner levels, you probably use gusta and gustan most often because the subjects are usually things or activities. But gustar is a regular -ar verb:

Subject	Form
yo	gusto
tú	gustas
él / ella	gusta
nosotros	gustamos
ellos / ellas	gustan

Me gustas.

The subject is tú. How do we know? Look at the verb: gustas → tú gustas. The conjugation tells us who the subject is.

2 Me gustas vs. te gusto

Spanish

Me gustas.

I like you.

Subject

tú

Person experiencing the feeling

yo

Spanish

Te gusto.

You like me.

Subject

yo

Person experiencing the feeling

tú

The two sentences use the same grammatical system. Only the roles have changed.

3 Use the conjugation to find the subject

Sentence	Verb form	Implied subject
Me gustas .	gustas	tú
Te gusto .	gusto	yo
Les gustamos .	gustamos	nosotros
Nos gustan .	gustan	ellos / ellas or a plural noun

Useful strategy: Can't find the subject? Look at the verb.

4 The complete paradigm

Imagine that María is the person who experiences the feeling. Change only the subject:

Subject	Sentence
yo	Yo le gusto a María.
tú	Tú le gustas a María.
él	Él le gusta a María.
nosotros	Nosotros le gustamos a María.
ellos	Ellos le gustan a María.

There is no special rule saying that gustar can only be used in the third person. Third-person forms are simply much more common at beginner levels.

5 This is the same structure you already know

Person experiencing the feeling	Pronoun	Verb	Subject
A María	le	gusta	la pizza
A María	le	gusto	yo
A María	le	gustas	tú
A María	le	gustamos	nosotros

The subject changed. Therefore, the verb changed. Nothing else about the basic system changed.

6 Changing the direction

Sentence	Subject	Meaning
Me gusta María.	María	I like María.
Le gusta a María.	yo	María likes me.
Nos gusta María.	María	We like María.
Le gustamos a María.	nosotros	María likes us.
Les gustan.	tú	They like you.
Te gustan.	ellos / ellas	You like them.

The pronoun tells us who experiences the feeling. The verb tells us information about the subject. Together, they tell us the direction of the relationship.

7 The subject can appear before or after the verb

Me gustas tú.

Tú me gustas.

A María le gusto yo.

Yo le gusto a María.

The word order changes, but the grammatical roles do not. This is why the color system follows grammatical function rather than position.

8 Gustar in other tenses

Tense	Example
Present	Le gusto a María .
Preterite	Le gusté desde el primer día.
Imperfect	Antes le gustaba .
Present perfect	Siempre me has gustado .
Future	Creo que les gustarás .
Conditional	Creo que le gustarías .

The tense changes; the basic relationship does not. The verb still agrees with its subject.

9 Applying the same analysis to other verbs

Sentence	How to find the subject
Me preocupas .	preocupas → tú
Me molestan tus comentarios .	molestan → plural; subject = tus comentarios
Nos interesas tú .	interesas → tú

The same questions still work: Who experiences the reaction? What is the subject? Does the verb agree with that subject?

10 Some verbs can also use other structures

Calling these “verbs like gustar” does not mean that each verb can only appear in this structure.

Gustar-like construction	Another structure
Me preocupa el examen.	Preocupo a mis padres.
Me molesta el ruido.	Juan molesta a su hermano.

The same verb can participate in different grammatical structures. “Verbs like gustar” is useful for recognizing this particular pattern; it does not mean every verb in the group must always use it.

11 Stop thinking of gustar as “backwards”

Once you understand the Spanish structure, you no longer need to mentally reverse an English sentence.

Spanish analysis	Result
Me = I experience the feeling; gustas = tú is the subject	Me gustas . → I like you.
Les = they experience the feeling; gustamos = nosotros is the subject	Les gustamos . → They like us.

This method works directly from Spanish grammar.

12 Final comparison

Spanish	Subject	Who experiences the feeling?	English meaning
Me gustas .	tú	yo	I like you.
Te gusto .	yo	tú	You like me.
Nos gustan .	ellos / ellas	nosotros	We like them.
Les gustamos .	nosotros	ellos / ellas	They like us.
Les gustas .	tú	ellos / ellas	They like you.
Te gustan .	ellos / ellas	tú	You like them.

13 The main idea

At beginner levels, gustar can look like a verb with only two useful forms: gusta and gustan. It isn't. Those forms are common because beginner sentences usually have third-person subjects.

Subject	Form
yo	gusto
tú	gustas
él / ella	gusta
nosotros	gustamos
ellos / ellas	gustan

This is not a new exception or a special advanced version of gustar. It is the logical consequence of the same principle learned in Guide I:

The verb agrees with its subject.